

Aex Meridian, LLC — Business Plan

Primary business plan and Claude Code project brief. Last updated July 2026.

1. Executive Summary

Aex Meridian, LLC is a single-member Colorado LLC that helps small businesses win more customers by giving them a premium-quality website they otherwise couldn't afford or build themselves — paired with ongoing hosting, maintenance, and (over time) other AI-assisted marketing services.

The core insight the business is built on: many small businesses have an outdated or nonexistent website, but lack either the technical skill or the budget to fix it through a traditional design agency. Aex Meridian closes that gap by using AI-assisted development (Claude Code + Astro) to build agency-quality sites at a fraction of the traditional cost and time, then selling the finished product directly to the business — not a proposal, a pitch deck, or a mockup, but a real, live website built specifically for them.

The company is bootstrapped, solo-operated, and run alongside the founder's undergraduate studies at Gonzaga University (Spokane, WA in the school year; Highlands Ranch, CO in the summer). It is intentionally lean: one person acting as designer, developer, salesperson, and account manager, with pricing and scope calibrated to what a single operator can realistically deliver.

2. Company Overview

Legal name	Aex Meridian, LLC
Structure	Single-member LLC, registered in Colorado
Founder / sole member	Caleb Aex
Locations	Spokane, WA (school year) / Highlands Ranch, CO (summer)
Stage	Pre-revenue / early revenue, Year 1

Team	One person, all roles, for at least the first 12 months
-------------	---

Mission: Give small businesses that can't afford — or don't have the know-how to build — a real online presence the ability to compete for local customers, through AI-built websites and approachable ongoing marketing support.

Operating philosophy: Use AI tooling to do the work of a small studio at solo-operator cost. Keep the offer simple, keep the price accessible while the company is new, and reinvest credibility (case studies, referrals, portfolio) before reinvesting price increases.

3. Products & Services

3.1 Core offering (Year 1 focus)

AI-built business website — one-time setup fee + monthly hosting/maintenance subscription.

- A complete, professional, mobile-ready website built for the client's specific business, using AI-assisted development rather than templates.
- Ongoing hosting, uptime, security, and minor content edits (contact info, hours, promotions, photos) included in the monthly subscription.
- The client is not asked to learn any tools, log into a CMS, or manage anything technically — Aex Meridian handles updates as a service by default.

3.2 Planned add-on services (post-Year-1 expansion)

Once the core website product is running smoothly, Aex Meridian will explore additional services for the same underserved niche — local businesses and individuals who don't have the time or expertise to use AI/online tools themselves:

- **AI-generated walkthrough videos** for realtors and short-term rental (Airbnb) hosts — a listing-marketing product adjacent to the core website business.
- **Social media content creation** — ongoing or batch-produced posts, using AI tools to generate and schedule content for clients who don't have time to run their own accounts.

These are explicitly *exploratory* additions, not committed Year-1 obligations. They should only be built out once the core website + retainer engine is stable and generating consistent monthly income.

4. Target Market & Client Profile

Primary target client: A small business that currently has **no website, or a badly outdated one**, and that has neither the technical skill to build a replacement nor the budget for a traditional design agency (which typically runs \$2,000–\$10,000+ for a custom build). This is a deliberately broad target — not restricted to a single industry — because the qualifying factor is the state of the business's current web presence and its price sensitivity, not its vertical.

Why this segment is reachable:

- A meaningful share of small businesses nationally still have no website or one that is slow, non-mobile-friendly, or years out of date.
- These businesses are typically not comparison-shopping web agencies — they're not in the market at all until someone shows them what's possible, which is exactly what a finished, ready-to-view AI-built site does.
- Local, in-person markets (Highlands Ranch/Douglas County, CO and Spokoo, WA/Spokane County) both have dense small-business populations across trades, health & wellness, professional services, retail, and hospitality — giving a large practical prospect pool in both of Aex Meridian's home markets without needing to specialize narrowly.

Note on niching: Later-stage growth may benefit from focusing outreach on a couple of verticals (e.g., trades/home services or health & wellness tend to have both high site-quality gaps and straightforward, replicable site structures). That is a *future optimization*, not a Year-1 requirement — the current plan targets any qualifying small business with an underdeveloped web presence.

5. Business Model & Client Acquisition Process

Aex Meridian's sales motion is distinctive: instead of pitching a proposal and building after the sale, the site is often **built first, on spec, then sold as a finished product**.

Standard process:

1. **Prospect identification** — the founder (acting as design specialist) searches Google Maps, local directories, and general web searches for small businesses in the target area with no website or a visibly outdated one.
2. **Speculative build** — using Claude Code + Astro, build a real, premium-quality website for that specific business (their name, services, photos where available, branding). AI-

assisted development means this can be done quickly and at very low marginal cost.

3. **Outreach** — cold call or cold email the business owner, leading with the finished website itself (“I built this for you — take a look”) rather than a generic pitch. This is a stronger, higher-trust opening than an audit or proposal, because the owner is evaluating a finished product, not a promise.
4. **Close** — if the business wants to move forward, they pay the one-time setup fee and begin the monthly subscription. The site goes live on their domain.
5. **Ongoing service** — Aex Meridian hosts the site and handles maintenance/edits as part of the monthly fee.

This “build first, then sell” approach trades some upfront labor (on unsold builds) for a much stronger, higher-converting sales conversation — which matters most while the company has no case studies or reputation yet.

6. Pricing & Revenue Model

6.1 Launch pricing (current, Year 1)

Item	Price
One-time website setup fee	\$500–\$750
Monthly hosting & maintenance	\$35/month

This is intentionally an introductory rate reflecting the company’s current lack of track record and market experience. It is **not the long-term price** — it exists to reduce the barrier to a first “yes” while Aex Meridian builds a portfolio, testimonials, and referral flow.

6.2 Why start low, and when to raise prices

A lower entry price makes sense right now because:

- It removes price as an objection while there is no portfolio or reputation to point to.
- It gets real websites live faster, which is the fastest path to case studies and referrals.
- It lets the founder learn the actual time cost of a build/edit before committing to a pricing structure meant to scale.

Reassessment triggers (revisit pricing when *any* of these hit):

- 5+ paying clients on the books and at least one usable case study/testimonial.
- Consistent full-price close rate above ~50% on qualified prospects at current pricing (a signal you're underpriced relative to demand).
- Monthly edit/support time consistently exceeding what \$35/month can sustain per client as client count grows.

6.3 Revenue math — know your numbers at \$35/month

At \$35/month, recurring revenue alone requires meaningful client volume to matter:

Target annual recurring revenue	Clients needed at \$35/mo
\$6,000/yr	~14 clients
\$12,000/yr	~29 clients
\$25,000/yr	~60 clients

The setup fee (\$500–\$750/client) is what generates most usable cash in Year 1; the monthly fee is what compounds over time and is the number to watch as the client base grows.

Track monthly recurring revenue (MRR) monthly — it is the single most important number in the business, even though it starts small at this price point.

Practical implication: because \$35/month is low relative to the labor required to host and support a site well, keep the scope of what's included in the monthly fee tight (hosting, uptime, small text/photo edits) so the retainer stays profitable per client as volume grows. Larger change requests should be scoped and billed separately rather than absorbed into the \$35 fee.

7. Technology Stack & Build Workflow

7.1 Confirmed stack

Layer	Tool	Notes
Framework	Astro	Default framework for all client sites — fast, simple, low ongoing maintenance
AI development	Claude Code	Used for the actual build and for every future edit/revision

Editor	Visual Studio Code	Primary local development environment
Version control	GitHub	One repository per client project
Payments	U.S. Bank online merchant services	Handles setup fee and monthly subscription charges

7.2 Hosting (recommended, not yet finalized)

The plan doesn't specify a hosting provider. Given the Astro-based stack, **Cloudflare Pages** is the natural fit: it deploys directly from a GitHub repo, has a generous free tier well-suited to many low-traffic small-business sites, and provides free SSL and custom domain support — keeping hosting cost near zero even as the client roster grows. This is a technical recommendation to evaluate, not a fixed decision.

7.3 Standard build workflow

1. Identify prospect and gather any available public info (business name, services, location, photos, existing content if any).
2. Create a new GitHub repository for the project (`client-businessname`).
3. Build the site in Astro using Claude Code, working from a reusable component/template library to keep build time low.
4. Review internally: mobile responsiveness, working links/contact form, page speed, no placeholder content.
5. Once a client agrees to move forward: collect final content/approval, finalize the design, and deploy.
6. Set up hosting and point the domain (register a new domain for the client if they don't have one, or coordinate DNS changes if they do — being careful not to disrupt any existing email service tied to the domain).
7. Verify the live site, confirm the setup fee has been collected, and start the monthly subscription billing cycle.
8. For ongoing edits: client emails or calls with the change, founder makes it via Claude Code, and pushes the update — no client-facing editing tools needed by default.

7.4 Brand identity (for Claude Code reference when building the Aex Meridian site itself)

The Aex Meridian brand direction has already been settled and should be treated as fixed

input when building the company's own website or any client-facing collateral:

- **Monogram:** clean serif or serif-sans hybrid "AM" mark.
 - **Hero element:** a chrome/silver wave motif.
 - **Color palette:** navy-forward —
 - Navy-black base
 - Steel blue #6B87A8
 - Slate-teal #3D6B6B
 - Warm ivory #F7F5F0
 - **Explicitly rejected directions:** gold, neon/glitch, rose gold/diamond, carbon-fiber, rainbow wave.
 - **Positioning:** the Aex Meridian site's job is credibility validation for prospects who land on it after being contacted, not lead generation — design and copy should signal trust and premium quality immediately (first-impression research suggests visual polish forms an opinion within roughly 50ms), even though the underlying company is new and small.
-

8. Payments & Contracts

- **Payment processing:** U.S. Bank's online merchant program handles both the one-time setup fee and the recurring monthly charge. Confirm directly with U.S. Bank whether their merchant portal supports automated recurring billing natively, or whether monthly charges need to be processed manually each billing cycle — this affects how much admin time recurring billing takes as the client count grows.
- **Contract basics to put in writing with every client** (even a simple one-page agreement):
 - Scope of the build (pages, features, number of included revision rounds).
 - Setup fee and monthly fee amounts, and what's included in the monthly fee.
 - Who owns what: the client always owns their domain name; the client owns their final content and brand assets; Aex Meridian retains the codebase/hosting arrangement during the active subscription.
 - Minimum term (if any) and what happens if a client cancels early.
 - What happens if a client leaves: they get their domain, their content, and reasonable

help transitioning away — never withhold what the client owns.

- No work begins before the setup fee is paid.
 - No site goes live before the client has approved it in writing (an email reply is fine).
-

9. Operations & Roles

For at least the first year, one person — the founder and sole LLC member — performs every function in the business:

- **Sales:** prospecting, speculative builds, outreach, closing.
- **Production:** design, development, and every subsequent edit.
- **Account management:** onboarding, ongoing client communication, billing follow-up.
- **Admin/legal:** LLC compliance, contracts, bookkeeping.

This is a deliberate constraint, not a gap to be filled immediately — pricing, scope, and volume targets in this plan are all sized to what one person can sustainably deliver. Hiring or subcontracting should only be considered once:

- Utilization is consistently high (little slack time for new prospecting/building), **and**
 - Monthly recurring revenue comfortably covers the added cost with margin to spare.
-

10. Differentiation

Aex Meridian competes primarily against three alternatives a prospect might otherwise choose:

- **Doing nothing / DIY builders (Wix, Squarespace, GoDaddy):** these require the owner's own time and skill to set up and maintain — exactly what the target client doesn't have. Aex Meridian removes that burden entirely.
- **Freelancers/marketplaces (Fiverr, Upwork):** inconsistent quality, no local presence, no ongoing relationship. Aex Meridian offers a real, accountable, local point of contact and a maintained product, not a one-off delivery.
- **Traditional design agencies:** far more expensive and slower (often weeks to months, thousands of dollars). AI-assisted development lets Aex Meridian deliver comparable quality much faster and at a fraction of the cost — which is also why the speculative,

“here’s your finished site” outreach approach works: it would be uneconomical for a traditional agency to build first and sell after.

The core differentiator to lead with in every pitch: **“I already built this for you — take a look,”** backed by real AI-assisted speed and a genuinely maintained, hosted product afterward (not a handoff-and-disappear freelance job).

11. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Speculative builds take time with no guarantee of a sale	Keep a reusable Astro component library so each new build is fast; treat unsold builds as a portfolio asset even if the prospect doesn't convert
\$35/month may not sustainably cover support time at scale	Keep monthly-plan scope tight; track time spent per client; revisit pricing at the triggers in Section 6.2
Solo capacity limits growth	Growth is intentionally paced to what one person can deliver; hire only against the triggers in Section 9
No portfolio/credibility as a new company	The “already-built” outreach model itself substitutes for a portfolio in the early going; convert every early client into a testimonial/case study
Client’s existing domain/email breaks during migration	Always confirm whether email runs on the domain before touching DNS; document existing DNS records before changing anything; never cancel a client’s old hosting until the new site is verified live
Time conflict with school schedule	Treat the business as a fixed weekly time block; build in buffers around exams

12. Growth Path (Directional, Beyond Year 1)

This is a lightweight outlook, not a commitment — the near-term focus is landing and retaining the first clients at the Section 6.1 pricing.

- **Year 1:** Validate the speculative-build → cold outreach → setup fee + \$35/month model.

Land the first handful of clients. Build a reusable Astro component library. Collect testimonials/case studies.

- **Year 2 (directional):** Reassess pricing per Section 6.2 triggers once there's a real portfolio and reputation. Consider whether a light niche focus (e.g., trades or wellness) is improving close rates enough to justify narrowing outreach. Explore the walkthrough-video or social-content add-ons once the core product is running smoothly.
 - **Beyond:** Only consider bringing on help (contractor or hire) once utilization and MRR triggers in Section 9 are both met.
-

13. Legal & Compliance Notes

- Aex Meridian, LLC is a Colorado single-member LLC. The operating agreement has been amended to include maximum member flexibility provisions (conversion/restructuring authority, tax election flexibility, management structure flexibility, and a reserved authority catch-all).
 - Have a Colorado-licensed attorney review client contract templates (ownership, termination, and payment terms) before wide use — this plan's contract guidance (Section 8) is operational, not legal advice.
 - Maintain basic bookkeeping separating business and personal finances from day one, even as a single-member LLC.
-

Appendix: Notes for Claude Code

When this document is provided to Claude Code as project context (e.g., for building the Aex Meridian company website or a client site), the following should be treated as fixed constraints:

- Tech stack: **Astro**, developed via **Claude Code**, version-controlled in **GitHub**, and (recommended) deployed to **Cloudflare Pages**.
- Brand system for the Aex Meridian company site: see Section 7.4 for the finalized monogram, color palette, and hero concept — do not introduce new color directions (gold, neon, rose gold, carbon-fiber, and rainbow themes have all been explicitly ruled out).
- The Aex Meridian company site's purpose is **credibility validation** for prospects who are contacted directly — not lead generation via SEO/ads. Design and copy should read

as premium and trustworthy immediately.

- For client project sites, default to a clean, mobile-first, fast-loading build with no client-facing editing dashboard by default (edits are handled by the founder via Claude Code as part of the monthly retainer).